

Continuing fears about ICE put early education at risk

Programs that rely on immigrant labor struggle to keep staff



FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Miss Kalicia (center) helped the children with arts and crafts at Ellis Early Learning, which operates three centers in Boston.

By Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

Ellis Early Learning opened in 1885 as a haven for South End children who hawked newspapers and shined shoes on the street. The school has endured as a Boston institution, serving as a national model for early childhood education.

But now, as Ellis teaches ABCs and other fundamentals to some 300 children under age 5, the school faces an existential threat in the wake of President Trump's aggressive crackdown on immigration.

Early childhood education programs rely heavily on immigrant labor, and fear of federal agents has forced the programs to change how they operate. Teachers have stopped taking students to parks and playgrounds. The schools have posted "private property" signs to discourage federal authorities from entering buildings without permission.

The specter of US Immigration and Customs

Since the beginning of President Trump's second term, **39,000** foreign-born workers have left the early childhood education industry nationwide.

Enforcement has made it harder for Ellis and other early childhood programs across Boston to keep employees in an industry that has long grappled with high turnover and low wages. Ellis alone lost two teachers because their work authorizations weren't renewed.

Since the beginning of Trump's second term, 39,000 foreign-born workers have left the industry nationwide, according to a study by researchers from Arizona State and American universities. It's unclear how many were in the Boston area, but nearly one out of three of early childhood education staff in Massachusetts are immigrants.

The fear that federal agents could show up unannounced at one of Ellis's three schools nearly kept the chief executive officer, Lauren Cook, from taking a much needed vacation. Cook worried that a visit from immigration officials could trigger a crisis beyond her control.

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College shaken by ex-leader's behavior

Officials accused of keeping Cape students and faculty in the dark

By Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

Faculty and students at Cape Cod Community College said they were stunned to learn only now that the former president had stepped down in March over an inappropriate relationship with a female student. They said they were appalled by his behavior and angry at school officials for their handling of the situation.

The Globe reported on Wednesday that an external investigation commissioned by the school found that the former president, John Cox, had an "ongoing pattern of inappropriate and excessive contact" with the student for as long as six months, and that other school officials initially failed to report the situation.

"I find the actions of the former president, as reported by the Boston Globe, to be beyond inappropriate," said Sean Corby, a student studying graphic design. "But what I think is just as wrong is how school administrators have chosen to handle the situation."

The college's board of trustees has still not publicly released the results of the investigation, which is dated Feb. 24, and some on campus said they were upset at having to learn from the news media why Cox abruptly left after being placed on leave

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Authorities criticized for waiting to share police video

By Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

After a 2015 fatal police shooting in Roxbury, Boston police leaders and local prosecutors quickly released video footage of what happened — a practice they pledged to continue, even in future cases that could reflect badly on law enforcement.

Over 10 years later, however, and despite the ubiquitous presence of body-worn cameras, they haven't released footage from the recent police killing of Stephenson King Jr., a shooting that prosecutors quickly deemed unreasonable and unjustified.

After the Suffolk district attorney's office acted swiftly to charge an officer with manslaughter last month, authorities said sharing the video now would jeopardize their case.

But critics are skeptical, arguing that the discrepancy raises questions about whether authorities are picking and choosing when to be transparent.

Other cities have issued guidance and timelines to promote consistency. And the public has largely become accustomed to seeing the footage in high-profile cases nationwide, from the recent DUI arrest of Tiger Woods following a crash last month,

BODYCAM, Page B4

Todd Lyons, acting director of ICE, and a South Boston native, said he'll resign at the end of May, shaking up the leadership at the agency responsible for carrying out President Trump's deportation campaign. **A4.**

Mayor Michelle Wu appointed Rodney Marshall as the new fire commissioner, making him the first Black man to lead the department. **B1.**

President Trump announced a 10-day cease-fire between Israel and Lebanon, a pause that could remove a major hurdle in broader peace talks. **A3.**

The Celtics and Bruins are getting ready for the playoffs, starting Sunday for both. **C1.**

Goal of fake robberies was getting visas

US program protects noncitizen victims of certain crimes

By Shelley Murphy
GLOBE STAFF

On a June afternoon in 2023, police received a frantic 911 call from a Weymouth liquor store. The place had just been robbed by a masked man brandishing a gun, the latest in a string of robberies.

Or so it seemed.

Dipikaben Patel, owner of Michael's Wine & Spirits, and her brother, Rameshbhai Patel, reported

that a gunman had burst into their store, then "ordered them on the ground and kicked Rameshbhai Patel to get him down." The man grabbed \$600 from the register and fled with the help of a getaway driver, according to court filings.

Several months earlier, on March 22, a similar armed robbery had been reported at Richdale Food Shops in Hingham. Co-owner Jiten-drakumar Patel told police that a gun-toting robber came in while he was working in the store with two others, including a man with high blood pressure who was so scared he needed medical assistance after-

ward.

The co-owner provided surveillance video that showed a masked man wearing a New York Yankees cap and pointing a pistol inside the store.

Only it was apparently all a ruse: federal prosecutors allege both hold-ups were staged as part of a sophisticated immigration fraud scam. Rameshbhai Patel, 52, of Kentucky, allegedly paid his former roommate between \$30,000 and \$35,000 to carry a fake gun and pretend to rob the Weymouth liquor store.

Jitendrakumar Patel, 39, of

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Eaves dropper

Friday: Showers early. High 63-68. Low 47-52.

Saturday: Cooler, damp. High 48-53. Low 43-48.

Sunrise: 6:00 Sunset: 7:28

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Bananas
\$0.49-\$0.89/lb



Blueberries
\$5.99-\$13.30/pint



Green seedless grapes
\$3.49-\$10.95/lb



Raspberries
\$7.99-\$18.64/lb



Cantaloupe
\$0.99-\$4.99/each

ADOBE STOCK

Eye-popping fruit prices are throwing consumers for a loop

By Lindsay Crudele
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

It's not just gas stations where Massachusetts consumers are seeing erratic prices. It's also in the produce section at Boston-area supermarkets: Some raspberries now cost as much as \$18 a pound and blueberries as much as \$14 a quart.

According to the USDA's Consumer Price Index, food

prices nationwide in February rose 3.1 percent over the previous year. Fruit decreased in price by 0.3 percent but is expected to rise 0.3 percent in the coming year.

President Trump campaigned on a promise of delivering cheaper groceries. Now, more than a month into a war with Iran, the United States is blockading the Strait of Hor-

muz, sending oil prices higher and driving up the cost of transportation.

Even when more New England produce becomes available in the coming months, buying local may not be a workaround, as farmers rely on oil products in their operations, from tractors to fertilizer.

Fruit is different from other foods, with price changes that

can be more turbulent. Experts said a trio of factors — oil costs, labor shortages, and tariffs — could drive prices up.

Basically no fruit is in season in Massachusetts right now, so at the big stores, everything's been shipped.

In a 13-store survey over the weekend, the Globe took a snapshot of Boston-area fruit prices. Trader Joe's charged 23

cents per individual Chiquita banana. Sounds like a deal, but let's do a little napkin math. A 6-ounce banana will cost 61 cents a pound at that price. If that banana weighed 4.16 ounces, as the USDA estimates it might, that would be around 88 cents a pound. The national average hit 67 cents in September. You could do better at Weg-

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